MODULE 00 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

How This Course Works

HashiCorp Certified: Terraform Associate (004). Twenty-nine modules, just under seven hours.

EXAM TA-004 TERRAFORM 1.12 RUNTIME 6h 58m

admin@sthithapragna.com

A course built to make you **understand** Terraform well enough to pass, rather than to recognise answers.

admin@sthithapragna.com

What is in the course

PART	WHAT IT COVERS
Modules 1 to 23	The eight exam domains, in the order they build on each other
Module 24	Confusion pairs. Mechanisms that get mistaken for each other
Module 25	Version currency. What changed after the version the exam tests
Module 26	Exam mechanics. Format, timing and strategy
Practice exams 1 to 3	Sixty original questions, mixed domains, timed

ON THE EXAM

Modules 24 to 26 add no new Terraform. They convert what you know into marks, which is a different skill.

Contents: Domains 1 to 3

STARTS	MODULE
0:00	1. Infrastructure as Code, and Why Terraform
13:50	2. Architecture: Core, Providers, the Registry
30:26	3. Provider Versioning and the Lock File
45:17	4. State: What It Is, Why It Exists, What It Costs
1:00:25	5. The Core Workflow: init, plan, apply, destroy
1:17:31	6. Reading a Plan. fmt, validate, show, output, console

ON THE EXAM

State is taught here, in Domain 2, rather than waiting for Domain 6. Everything after module 4 depends on it.

Contents: Domain 4

STARTS	MODULE
1:31:54	7. Resources, Data Sources, References, Addressing
1:47:04	8. Variables, Outputs, Locals, and Precedence
2:03:39	9. Complex Types, Expressions and Functions
2:18:19	10. count, for_each and Dynamic Blocks
2:33:06	11. Dependencies and Lifecycle Rules
2:48:24	12. Custom Conditions and Check Blocks
3:01:38	13. Sensitive Data, Ephemeral Values, Write-Only

ON THE EXAM

Seven modules and nearly two hours. Domain 4 is the largest share of the exam and the part people find hardest.

Contents: Domains 5 to 7

STARTS	MODULE
3:17:48	14. Modules: Sourcing, Scope, Composition
3:32:46	15. Module Versioning and the Registry
3:45:08	16. Backends and State Locking
3:59:32	17. Drift, Refresh-Only, and the Refactoring Blocks
4:14:40	18. State Commands, and CLI Workspaces
4:28:46	19. Importing Existing Infrastructure
4:40:51	20. Logging, Debugging and Troubleshooting

ON THE EXAM

Modules 16 to 18 return to state, now that you have the language to describe what is happening to it.

Contents: Domain 8, and the rest

STARTS	MODULE
4:51:50	21. HCP Terraform: Workflows and Remote Operations
5:05:25	22. HCP Terraform: Workspaces, Projects, Variable Sets
5:19:18	23. HCP Terraform: Governance, Policy and Editions
5:32:57	24. Confusion Pairs
5:46:57	25. Version Currency: 1.12 Against Today
5:56:39	26. Exam Mechanics and Strategy

ON THE EXAM

Modules 24 to 26 add no new Terraform. They convert what you already know into marks.

Contents: The practice exams

STARTS	MODULE
6:07:12	Practice Exam 1 of 3 - 20 questions
6:23:57	Practice Exam 2 of 3 - 20 questions
6:40:30	Practice Exam 3 of 3 - 20 questions
6:58:25	End

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Sixty original questions. Take paper 1 straight after module 23, not at the end.

How a teaching module is built

- **Roughly twenty-five slides, twelve to fifteen minutes.** One sitting, not a lecture series.
- **It opens with the single idea** the module turns on, then develops it.
- **Every slide carries an 'on the exam' line** saying how that point is actually tested.
- **It closes with four or five worked scenarios**, then a recap you can rewatch alone.
- There are **109 worked scenarios** across the teaching modules, before the practice papers.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The recap slide at the end of each module is designed to be watched on its own the week before the exam.

The scenarios, and how to use them

- **A situation, a question, four options, then silence.** Answer before the walkthrough starts.
- **Do not skip the pause.** Watching someone else reason is not the same as reasoning.
- **Every wrong option is explained**, not just the right one. Wrong answers are where the learning is.
- **Most wrong options are true statements** about something adjacent. That is what makes them plausible.
- **Several scenarios have more than one workable answer.** One sentence in the situation decides.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If you find yourself agreeing with a wrong option's reasoning, that is the most valuable moment in the course.

The eight domains, and where they live

DOMAIN	MODULES
1. Infrastructure as Code concepts	Module 1
2. Terraform's purpose and architecture	Modules 2 to 4
3. Terraform basics and the core workflow	Modules 5 and 6
4. The configuration language	Modules 7 to 13
5. Modules	Modules 14 and 15
6. State management	Modules 16 to 18
7. Maintaining and troubleshooting	Modules 19 and 20
8. HCP Terraform	Modules 21 to 23

ON THE EXAM

Domain 4 gets seven modules because it is the largest and the hardest. State is taught early, in Domain 2, because everything later depends on it.

What is new in the 004 exam

- **depends_on and create_before_destroy lifecycle rules.** Module 11.
- **Validating configuration with custom conditions.** Module 12.
- **Ephemeral values and write-only arguments.** Module 13.
- **Organising HCP Terraform workspaces and projects.** Module 22.
- **If you studied for the 003 exam, these four are new.** Two of them describe features that did not exist then.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Material written for the 003 exam will not cover these at all, and much of it predates the features entirely.

Things this course corrects

- **The S3 and DynamoDB locking pattern is deprecated.** Nearly every guide still teaches it.
- **The dependency lock file covers providers only.** Modules are not recorded in it, whatever you have read.
- **sensitive controls display, never storage.** This one appears in five separate modules.
- **Variable validation can reference other variables** since 1.9. Older guides say it cannot.
- Each correction is sourced from HashiCorp's own documentation, and the module says where.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Everything on this list still appears in current, widely-read material. Working and current are not the same thing.

How to work through it

- **In order.** Later modules assume earlier ones, and reference them by number.
- **One or two modules a sitting.** Each is a self-contained argument; three in a row is diminishing returns.
- **Take practice exam 1 after module 23**, not at the end. It shows you where to spend the last week.
- **Then modules 24 to 26**, then papers 2 and 3 spaced a few days apart.
- **Rewatch the recap slides** in the final days. They exist for exactly that.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The single most useful moment is your first practice paper. Take it before you feel ready, because that is what it is for.

The practice exams

- **Sixty original questions** across three papers. None is taken from any question bank.
- **Twenty per paper, mixed domains**, weighted to match the exam's likely emphasis.
- **Nine seconds to answer each.** The real exam gives you about a minute per question.
- **Four questions deliberately invert an earlier one**, so no mechanism becomes learnable as always-wrong.
- **Score by domain, not by total.** Where you miss matters far more than how many.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The real exam gives you an objective-level report. Scoring these papers by domain is practice for reading it.

What this course does not do

- **It is not a substitute for writing Terraform.** This exam rewards people who have used it.
- **There are no labs.** Every module names what to try; do that in your own account.
- **It does not cover Terraform beyond 1.12**, except in module 25, which explains what changed.
- **It teaches no question bank.** If you want memorised answers, this is the wrong course.
- **It assumes you can read code**, and does not assume you have written Terraform before.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Pair this with a real account and a small project. The combination passes; either alone is weaker.

Before module 1

- **Install Terraform**, and check the version. Anything from 1.10 onwards behaves as described here.
- **Get a free-tier cloud account** you can safely destroy things in.
- **Bookmark the exam content list**, and use its links. They point at 1.12 documentation deliberately.
- **Do not book the exam yet.** Book it after your first practice paper, when you know where you stand.
- **Module 26 covers booking, format and timing** when you get there.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The exam is sixty minutes, one attempt, and no free retake. That is a good reason to book it once you have evidence.

Module 1 asks a question with a less obvious answer than it looks: **why does Infrastructure as Code exist at all?**

admin@sthithapragna.com